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Nº. 18

COLLECTION
SELLERS

Selling on Your Own or With a Broker: The Right Choice

Benefits, differences, savings and peace of mind: how to make the best decision for you.



2026 EDITION

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It presents general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. Every real estate situation is different, and you should consult the appropriate professionals before making a decision about a transaction.

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COLLECTION SELLERS · GUIDE NO. 18

Selling on Your Own or With a Broker

DuProprio vs. a real estate broker — the real math, no myths

“Why pay a commission if I can sell alone? » The question is legitimate, and deserves a real calculation rather than a slogan. Selling yourself may work for some; for others, the support of a broker brings in more than it costs.

This guide honestly compares the two options: what a broker really does, the real costs and risks of “no middleman”, and how to decide according to your situation.

Each chapter ends with a lined “My Notes” page to do YOUR calculation.

Sell alone or with a broker? The right answer depends on your market, your time, and your risk tolerance. This guide honestly compares the two paths - the real work of a broker, the costs and risks of "no middleman", and calculating the net in your pocket.

Objective: decide with full knowledge of the facts, figures and responsibilities in hand.

CHAPTER

What a broker really does

> *See the full work behind the commission.*

- Set the right price (comparative analysis) and advise the strategy.
- Prepare, photograph and market (Centris, network of brokers, wide distribution).
- Filter buyers, organize and manage visits.
- Negotiate offers and conditions in your interest.
- Supervise the legal aspects (forms, seller's declaration, deadlines) and secure the transaction up to the notary.

The commission pays for all of this work AND the network of buyers to which it gives access.

Beyond the display, a broker sets the right price, prepares the marketing, filters buyers, leads the negotiation and secures the legal aspects up to the notary. The commission pays for full work - and professional responsibility supervised by the OACIQ.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *The real question is not “how much does a broker cost?” » but “how much does it bring me, net, after commission?” ". A better sale price and a secure transaction often more than offset the fees.*

CHAPTER

The costs and risks of “no intermediary”

> *Evaluate what “selling alone” really entails.*

Selling alone is not free or without risk: platform package, purchase of your own services (photos, evaluation), time invested, and above all the risk of costly errors.

- Risk of incorrectly setting the price (too high: it drags; too low: deadweight loss).
- Often less exposure to the network of brokers and their buyers.
- Direct negotiation, without intermediary, often emotional.
- Legal risks: hidden defects, incorrectly completed seller's declaration, post-sales disputes.

Selling alone is neither free nor without risk: visibility packages, time, management of visits and above all legal responsibility. An error in the promise to purchase or an omission in the seller's declaration can cost much more than a commission.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *The costliest mistake in “selling alone” is almost always the price: a few percent less on a house is often much more than the commission saved.*

CHAPTER

The real calculation, numbers in hand

> *Compare the NET in your pocket in each scenario.*

Compare the NET amount you collect in each case, not just the commission avoided:

- Broker scenario: sales price (often optimized) – commission = net A.
- Scenario only: sales price (it's up to you to reach the right price) – platform fees and services – value of your time – risk = net B.
- The difference mainly depends on your ability to get the best price for yourself.

Many sellers discover that a good broker gets a premium price that covers their commission - while saving them the stress and risk.

Compare the NET actually collected in each scenario, not the commission in absolute value. A broker who gets a better price, faster and with less risk, can leave you as much - or even more - out of pocket than a poorly negotiated single sale.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Do the net calculation, honestly, including the value of your time and the risk of error. It's the only comparison that means anything.*

CHAPTER

How to decide based on your situation

> *Choose the option suited to YOUR case.*

Selling alone may be suitable if: you know the local market very well, your property is in high demand, you have the time, the ease in negotiation and the rigor for the legal aspect. Otherwise, the support of a broker reduces the risk and aims for a better net result.

There are also intermediate formulas (à la carte services). The important thing: to decide with full knowledge of the facts, with real calculation, not a reflex.

Selling alone may be suitable if you know the local market very well, have the time, are comfortable with paperwork and negotiation, and accept the risk. When in doubt, or for a complex property (co-ownership, inheritance, separation), the support quickly pays off.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *Meet a broker before deciding, even if you lean towards "alone": you will at least leave with a price analysis and a clear vision of the market - and often with a better decision.*

CHAPTER

Selling alone: essential precautions

> *Reduce risks if you do without a broker.*

Selling yourself is possible, but certain steps require rigor to avoid problems:

- Set a **realistic price** from real comparable sales.
- Correctly write the **seller's declaration**.
- Use **compliant documents** for the promise to purchase.
- Filter visitors and think about your **security**.
- Have the legal aspect validated by a **notary**.

What you save in commission, you pay for in time, risk and responsibility: to be evaluated honestly.

If you sell alone, cover at least the essentials: price based on comparables, rigorous declaration from the seller, compliant documents, security during visits, and legal validation by a notary. What you save in commission, you pay for in time and risk: evaluate it honestly.

> EMILIE'S ADVICE
>
> *If you sell alone, at least have the promise to purchase and the seller's declaration framed by a professional. A poorly drafted clause or omission can cost much more than a commission.*

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

> *Your next steps, concretely.*

This week

1. List sales tasks and assess which ones I can handle.
2. Estimate the value of my time and my ability to negotiate.

Within 30 days

1. Calculate the NET in your pocket in each scenario.
2. Meet with a broker to obtain a price analysis.

Then

1. Make an informed decision, figures in hand.

To decide

1. Calculate my estimated net pocket in each scenario.
2. Evaluate my available time, my legal comfort and the acceptable risk.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Commission: broker's fees, remunerating all sales work.
- Net in pocket: amount actually collected after all costs.
- Seller's declaration: key document to limit disputes over hidden defects.
- A la carte services: intermediate formulas between “only” and “full management”.
- Broker network: pool of buyers accessible via a broker.

- Commission: broker's remuneration, in exchange for a full mandate.
- OACIQ: organization that supervises brokers and protects the public.
- Net in pocket: amount actually collected after all costs.
- Seller's Declaration: form recording what the seller knows about the property.
- Legal liability: risk assumed by the seller who acts alone.

GO FURTHER

Quiz - test yourself

1. A broker's commission pays:

A) Nothing

B) Complete work and access to a network of buyers

C) Only a sign

D) The welcome tax

2. The right question to ask is:

A) How much does a broker cost?

B) How much does it net me, after commission?

C) What color sign?

D) None

3. The most costly mistake of "selling alone" is often:

A) The sign

B) The wrong price

C) The photos

D) Parking

4. Selling alone carries a legal risk of:

A) Nothing

B) Hidden defects and incorrectly completed seller's declaration

C) Too many buyers

D) Hidden commission

5. The good comparison is:

A) The commission avoided only

B) The NET in your pocket in each scenario

C) The asking price

D) Municipal assessment

6. Selling alone may be suitable if:

A) We don’t know the market

B) We know the market, we have the time and the legal and negotiation skills

C) We hate negotiating

D) We are running out of time

7. An intermediate formula exists in the form of:

A) Nothing

B) A la carte services

C) Mandatory auction

D) Gift of the house

8. Before deciding, it is advisable to:

A) Don't talk to anyone

B) Meet with a broker for a price analysis

C) Set the price at random

D) Copy neighbor

Answers

1. B - Price, marketing, visits, negotiation, legal (chap. 1).

2. B - We reason clearly (chap. 1).

3. B - A few % less exceeds the commission (chap. 2).

4. B - Possible after-sales disputes (chap. 2).

5. B - We compare the net, time and risk included (chap. 3).

6. B - It depends on your skills and availability (chap. 4).

7. B - A la carte options exist (chap. 4).

8. B - We decide with full knowledge of the facts (chap. 4).

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You now have the right keys in hand.

Every real estate journey is different.

If you would like to go further,
I would be happy to discuss
your project with you.



Make informed decisions.
Choose with confidence.
Live without regrets.
See you soon,
Emilie ☺

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